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< E-store brand personality
congruence for multichannel
apparel retail brands/>

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t003377 Introduction Today 's consumers are multichannel shoppers ***LOADED and frequently exposed to the same retailer from multiple channels , which makes them expect consistent shopping ***LOADED experiences from the retailer across all channels . Consumers ' perceptions and behaviors toward the brand in one channel can be affected by their experiences and perceptions from another channel . E-stores are particularly instrumental for consumers ' purchase decisions . E-commerce sales accounted for . % of all retail sales worldwide in and have seen incessant growths for the last decade with growths of – % every year in the US , while US total retail sales annual growths have remained at – % during the same period . More than % of US shoppers ***LOADED conduct online research before they buy products , and an average shopper ***LOADED visits an e-store . times before making a purchase . Therefore , e-stores play critical

roles in building , reinforcing and extending a retailer 's brand image , which highlights the importance of integrated management ***LOADED between a retailer 's existing brand image and its estore image . Nevertheless , few researchers ***LOADED have examined how the congruence/incongruence E-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence between a retail brand 's existing brand image and its e-store image may impact consumers ' response , a gap addressed in this study . The integrated marketing ***LOADED communication paradigm postulates that all forms of marketing ***LOADED communication , regardless of the channel or media used , must be managed ***LOADED to integrate and interact with each other in order to maximize the brand value . In line with the IMC concept , integrating diverse retail formats and maintaining an integrated concept by delivering a consistent brand image across channels is one of the critical challenges faced by multichannel retailers . Brand image consists of both functional and symbolic image dimensions , and both symbolic and functional image congruence is significant for a successful multichannel branding . However , existing channel integration research has weighed in the functional integration , such as integrations in management

***LOADED of the inventory , supply chain , or customer service ;
whereas the
issue of cross-channel symbolic image integration has been rarely
investigated
in spite of its significant influence to produce positive consumer
responses .

Therefore , this study will focus on the cross-channel integration
from the
symbolic image management ***LOADED perspective to fill the
aforementioned
literature gap by examining the role of e-store brand personality
***LOADED
congruence/incongruence in the overall image fit between the
brand and the
estore and its resultant effect on consumers ' patronage intention
.

Specifically , we chose personality ***LOADED as a critical
symbolic brand
image dimension to focus on in this study . Brand personality
***LOADED refers
to the brand 's human-like traits and has been known to play an
important role
in consumers ' symbolic use of brand image . The personality
***LOADED
perspective also has long been applied in the retail context as
store
personality ***LOADED and e-store personality ***LOADED as a
critical
symbolic image factor to drive consumers ' patronage behaviors ,
such as
repeated shopping ***LOADED at the store/e-store , spending
time in the
store/e-store and spreading a positive word-of-mouth . Hence ,
this study

examines how the incongruence between a multichannel retailer's brand personality ***LOADED and e-store personality ***LOADED influences consumers' perceived e-store brand fit, or subjective global judgment of the overall fit of the e-store image with the retail brand's image, and how this overall fit perception leads to the consumer's e-store patronage intention. Much literature on image congruence has been devoted to self-congruence effects, which refer to consumers' behaving favorably toward a brand or a store that they perceive to be congruent with their self-image and thus is relevant to themselves. The self-congruence literature suggests that even if consumers perceive that a multichannel retailer's e-store well represents the retailer's brand image, they are not likely to shop at the e-store if the retail brand is perceived to be irrelevant to them to begin with. Further, cognitive psychology theories, such as the elaboration likelihood model, suggest that the personal relevance of a communication positively drives how critically individuals process information in the communication, leading to more issue-relevant attitudinal or behavioral responses to the communication. Therefore, this study examines the potential moderating role of the retail

brand 's self-relevance to the consumer in altering the relationship between consumers ' perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention . We used vertically-integrated multichannel apparel specialty retailers which sell only their own private label apparel products as the context of this study because symbolic congruence is of particular importance in apparel shopping ***LOADED given the highly experiential and expressive nature of the product . Further , by using vertically-integrated specialty retailers , we avoided potential confounding effects of the interaction between the product brand image and the retail brand image . , Literature review and hypotheses Brand personality ***LOADED and e-store personality ***LOADED Brand image refers to a consumer 's perception of a brand reflecting diverse associations about the brand held in the consumer 's memory , encompassing product- or non-productrelated attributes and functional or symbolic benefits characterizing the brand . Brand image has a strong connection ***LOADED to the consumer decision-making process . Among many types of brand associations , consumers often associate brands with symbolic meanings ***LOADED beyond tangible benefits of product features or performance . A large part of the symbolic brand associations constituting a brand 's image is linked to user

***LOADED imagery . The user ***LOADED imagery leads consumers to view the brand as if it were a person and associate the brand with brand personality
***LOADED , or a " set of human characteristics " . Brand personality
***LOADED has been extensively examined as a symbolic brand image dimension because of its pivotal role in driving consumer decision making . Similarly , store image refers to an overall impression of a store as perceived by a consumer . Martineau described store image as " the way in which the store is defined in the shoppers ***LOADED ' mind , partly by its functional qualities and partly by an aura of psychological attributes " . Between functional and psychological aspects of a store image , Martineau argued that the subjectively-judged psychological image , or store personality ***LOADED , may have a greater impact on shoppers ***LOADED ' responses . Just as brand personality ***LOADED addresses human-like traits of a brand , store personality ***LOADED also consists of human-like characteristics that consumers perceive a store possesses . The concepts of store personality ***LOADED and brand personality ***LOADED have been expanded to the online context . For example , Okazaki examined online brand personalities ***LOADED

of e-stores of American brands in five countries and found that many brand personality ***LOADED dimensions that were previously identified for offline contexts were applicable to online contexts . Other researchers ***LOADED have also confirmed the applicability of traditional brand personality ***LOADED dimensions to measure website personality ***LOADED across different cultures or the applicability of store personality ***LOADED dimensions to e-store personality ***LOADED . Therefore , extending the concept of store personality ***LOADED to e-store contexts , e-store personality ***LOADED is defined in this study as the human-like characteristics of an e-store perceived by consumers . E-store personality ***LOADED has been found to impact online consumers ' perceptions and purchase intention with respect to the e-store .

E-store brand image congruence/incongruence Image congruence refers to how congruent the images of two entities are with each other . In this study , two variables , perceived e-store brand fit and e-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence , are conceptualized in the context of e-store brand image congruence . These two variables differ both conceptually and operationally . First , conceptually , e-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence captures

image congruence only in the personality ***LOADED aspect .
Personality

***LOADED is a type of symbolic brand associations constituting the brand 's

and the e-store 's images . On the other hand , perceived e-store brand fit

reflects the holistic image congruence from the similarity between the overall

brand image , which encompasses all functional or symbolic brand associations

and the e-store image , or the overall impression of the e-store encompassing

the functional and symbolic E-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence

attributes of the e-store and Martineau discussed earlier) .

Second ,

operationally , in this study , the direct approach is used to assess e-store

brand fit , whereas e-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence is measured

using the indirect approach , based on the direct and indirect approaches to

measuring image congruence frequently used in past studies .

The direct

approach operationalizes image congruence as the holistic assessment by

directly asking respondents to indicate how congruent the two images are . On

the other hand , the indirect approach to the operationalization of image

congruence entails first separately measuring the images of each entity , from

which a discrepancy between the two image scores is estimated indirectly ; a

lower incongruence score would indicate higher image congruence . E-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence/incongruence From the perspective of the IMC paradigm , Keller emphasized the importance of strategic selection ***LOADED and design of online marketing ***LOADED options that match communication options in other channels . In the same vein , Rubinstein and Griffiths argued two factors for online branding success : " integrating all the expression of the brand " and " delivering a consistent brand experience " , which correspond to the symbolic and functional congruence , respectively . Kwon and Lennon provided empirical support for this argument through their finding ***LOADED that retailers ' offline and online brand images had reciprocal influences on each other ; specifically , consumers ' brand beliefs and attitudes in one channel were affected by their experience from the other channel . Further , Da Silva and Syed Alwi argued that the symbolic cross-channel brand image consistency relating to intangible and emotional values may provide a more sustainable competitive advantage than does the functional integration across channels . Despite the importance of the intangible symbolic image congruence in multichannel retail branding , most existing literature on channel

integration has been mainly focused on operational integration . For instance , researchers ***LOADED rather stressed utilitarian integration in tangible attributes of the retailer , such as merchandise accessibility , product availability , customer service , product quality , price , privacy and security . They tended to leave out the symbolic integration of brand image , such as the esthetic impression of the e-store design that matches its brand personality ***LOADED despite the key role of symbolic brand image consistency in successful branding . Addressing this gap , we identify personality ***LOADED as a symbolic image dimension applicable to both a multichannel retailer 's brand and e-store and define e-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence as the degree to which the personality ***LOADED a consumer perceives from a multichannel retailer 's e-store is similar to the brand personality ***LOADED that the consumer associates with the retailer based on his or her prior experience . Adopting an indirect approach to measure e-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence , we used e-store brand incongruence as our variable name to match it with the discrepancy operationalization through the indirect method . Perceived e-store brand fit Perceived fit refers to

consumers' holistic perception of the similarity, connectedness, or

compatibility between two objects. The role of perceived fit in marketing

***LOADED has been extensively investigated in brand extension literature.

Brand extension is defined as the use of an existing brand name for a new

product in order to facilitate entering new product categories or new market

segments. Perceived fit between the parent brand and the extension has been

known to play a critical role in the success of a brand extension strategy. In

this study, perceived e-store brand fit is defined as a consumer's subjective

global judgment of how well an apparel retail brand's e-store reflects the

brand. Offline retailers' expansion to the Internet is analogous to a product

brand's extension into another product category. Just as product brand

extensions use existing familiar name of their parent brands to take advantage

of their halo effect to foster trust in new products, offline retailers have

expanded to the Internet under the same retailer name that they have used

offline in order to leverage positive existing brand images to reduce consumers

' perceived risk and enhance trust in their online stores and save the costs of

establishing new store concepts or images on the Internet.

Perceived brand fit

may be formed based on both functional and symbolic images of the entities .

Thus , consumers ' perceived e-store brand fit may be influenced both by how

similar the e-store 's concrete , functional characteristics are to the

functional attributes and benefits consumers associate with the brand and by

how congruent the abstract , symbolic characteristics of the e-store are with

the symbolic image of the brand . Therefore , perceived e-store brand fit can

be regarded as the overall e-store brand image congruence encompassing both

functional and symbolic image congruencies . Arslan and Altuna stressed that

consumers tended to evaluate the brand positively through the perception of fit

based on the product-level similarity as well as based on the unique image

associations with various attributes and benefits offered by the brand .

Similarly , Eren-Erdogmus et al. identified factors influencing perceived fit ,

such as consumer personality ***LOADED , brand attitude and consumer values ,

including functional , hedonic and symbolic values . Among them , symbolic

value is one of the necessary antecedents to form the perception of fit and the

most significant driver of successful branding . Given this literature , it is

feasible that the congruence between a retailer 's brand personality ***LOADED

and e-store personality ***LOADED , which constitutes large parts of the retailer 's symbolic values , positively influences consumers ' perceived overall fit of the e-store to the brand . d'Astous and Levesque also support this view by stressing that the overall brand image consists of functional and symbolic brand image aspects , and personality ***LOADED , as a symbolic image , does not substitute but complements the overall image . Therefore , the following hypothesis is proposed : H . The greater the e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence , the lower the perceived e-store brand fit . E-store patronage intention E-store patronage intention represents consumers ' willingness to engage in diverse favorable behaviors toward an e-store , encompassing shopping ***LOADED at the e-store , spending time in it and recommending it to other consumers . Therefore , how perceived e-store brand perceived fit influences consumers ' patronage intention toward the brand 's e-store bears an important strategic meaning ***LOADED . Perceived fit has been found to be a significant predictor of consumer responses to a product extension . For instance , a poor perceived fit between an extension and its parent brand can hurt consumers ' favorable associations or attitudes toward

the parent brand and transfer undesirable or harmful messages to the extension

. A low perceived fit between a parent brand and an extension can lead

consumers to question the purpose of the E-store brand personality ***LOADED

congruence extension ; whereas a high perceived fit generates consumers '

favorable behavioral responses toward the extension , including increased

purchase intention . Given the analogy between brand extensions and retailers '

multichannel expansions , the aforementioned findings

***LOADED on the

brand-extension fit lend support for a prediction that perceived e-store brand

fit has a positive influence on consumers ' intention to patronize the e-store

, as in the following hypothesis : H . The greater the perceived e-store brand

fit , the greater the e-store patronage intention . As previously discussed ,

perceived e-store brand fit captures consumers ' global perception of the fit

between the brand and its e-store and thus encompasses all possible aspects

consumers use to compare the brand and its e-store . On the other hand ,

e-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence/incongruence reflects the

similarity/difference between the brand and the e-store specific to the

personality ***LOADED dimension of symbolic images . Hence , we predict that

the holistic perceived e-store brand fit is likely to be a more direct

predictor of consumers' e-store patronage intention than the e-store brand

personality ***LOADED incongruence operationalized as the difference between

the brand and its e-store that is computed only in terms of personality

***LOADED . In other words , a multichannel retailer's e-store brand

personality ***LOADED incongruence is likely to impact consumers' patronage

intention toward the e-store indirectly through influencing the consumers'

perceived e-store brand fit . The following hypothesis reflects this prediction

: H . Consumers' perceived e-store brand fit mediates the influence of the

e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence on e-store patronage

intention . Self-relevance of the retail brand The self-relevance of the retail

brand refers to the extent to which consumers perceive a retail brand to be

personally relevant to themselves and meet their needs/wants . Personal

relevance has been known as a key motivator for thoughtful information

processing . The elaboration likelihood model postulates that people process a

communication with varying levels of elaboration , or extent of cognitive

efforts exerted to think about issues in the message . People sometimes

carefully process issues in a given communication , while other times they may

pay little attention to them . A plethora of the literature has proposed and empirically demonstrated personal relevance as a positive motivator of elaboration . That is , when the message is perceived to be relevant to them , people tend to evaluate them with more critical eyes . As a result , elaboration levels impact persuasive outcomes in that individuals ' response to a communication tends to be better in line with issue-relevant judgment in the high-elaboration , central-route processing mode than in the low-elaboration , peripheral-route processing mode . For example , in the context of celebrity endorsement based brand advertising , Malodia et al. found that the more involved the consumer was with the brand , the greater the impact of how well the celebrity reinforced the brand personality ***LOADED on the consumer 's brand attitude . Based on this theoretical and empirical literature , it is plausible that when shopping ***LOADED in a multichannel apparel retail brand 's e-store , consumers who feel the brand is highly relevant to them would be more likely to scrutinize the e-store brand fit and thus be more profoundly affected by this fit judgment in forming their e-store patronage intention as compared to consumers who find the brand irrelevant to them . No matter how well the e-store fits the retailer 's brand image , if consumers think that the

retailer does not offer the types of products they want or welcome the type of consumers they are , and thus is not relevant to them , the e-store brand fit will not matter to them . Hence , we predict the moderating role of the consumer 's perceived self-relevance of the retail brand for , the relationship between perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention as follows : H . The relationship between perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention is greater among consumers who perceive a high level of self-relevance of the retail brand .

Methods

Sample and procedure

An online survey was conducted with a US national sample of female online clothing shoppers ***LOADED , recruited from a market research firm 's consumer panel . Only a female sample was recruited for the gender consistency between the sample and the target market of the brands used in this study because two of the six brands used in this study were considered targeting only female consumers . Moreover , researchers ***LOADED have shown that fashion brands ' symbolic image is of a higher value to women than to men , which further justifies the use of a female sample . On the questionnaire , respondents were first asked to complete the brand personality ***LOADED and brand

self-relevance measures for an apparel retail brand randomly assigned to them among six brands selected for this study .We used multiple brands , instead of a single brand , as the contexts in which respondents completed the survey to enhance the generalizability through stimulus sampling . Random assignments of participants ***LOADED to the brands were expected to help avoid bias in the sample-brand groupings while generating a sufficient variance in the relevance of the brand to the participant ***LOADED . The six brands were selected through a content analysis of over apparel brands and their e-stores . In the open-coding process , two coders coded the apparel brands in terms of the visual merchandising cues used by the e-stores to convey symbolic e-store images and the functional features of the e-store . Then , the researchers ***LOADED conducted an axial coding process by integrating the open codes to identify potential types of symbolic images conveyed by the estores , which informed our selection ***LOADED of the six brands . Care was taken to select brands that represented diverse types of symbolic e-store images . After completing the brand personality ***LOADED and self-relevance measures , respondents were given a link to their assigned apparel brand 's e-store .

Respondents were asked to browse the e-store to select a pair of pants that they would like to buy for themselves , return to the survey website and enter the item number or name of the pants that they selected . This process ensured that respondents had a chance to browse their assigned e-store and form an impression of the e-store 's image including its personality ***LOADED .

Following the e-store browsing task , respondents filled out the remaining questionnaire including measures for e-store personality ***LOADED , perceived e-store brand fit , e-store patronage intention and demographic items . The mean age of the respondents was . years old . The sample size was similar across the six brands . Most respondents had at least some college education , were non-Hispanic White and came from a household with incomes that ranged between \$, and \$, . Instruments Self-relevance of the retail brand was measured with five self-relevance sub-scale items adapted from Kwon and Lennon 's offline brand belief scale . Perceived e-store brand fit E-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence was measured by three Likert-scale items inspired by Becker-Olsen and Hill 's perceived fit scale . Becker-Olsen and Hill used a semantic differential scale including seven pairs of bipolar

adjectives or phrases to measure perceived fit between a brand and its sponsorship program . In this study , three of their items were selected and modified in declarative statements that clearly communicate the e-store brand fit context used in this study while preserving the fit concepts captured in the original items . To measure e-store patronage intention , we used seven items in a Likert scale format including four new items and three items modified from previous studies . The self-relevance , perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention items were all rated using a - point scale . Each of brand personality ***LOADED and e-store personality ***LOADED was measured using a scale adapted from d'Astous and Levesque 's store personality ***LOADED scale . The validity and reliability of this scale have been established in past research in both offline and online store contexts . The original scale consists of pairs of bipolar adjectives describing five store personality ***LOADED dimensions including enthusiasm , sophistication , genuineness , solidity and unpleasantness . In this study , the personality ***LOADED adjectives were modified into a sentence format to fit the brand and e-store personality ***LOADED contexts and were rated on a - point Likert scale

ranging from to . Results Preliminary analyses Since this study adapted d'Astous and Levesque 's store personality ***LOADED scale with significant modifications to measure personality ***LOADED in the two contexts , we first conducted exploratory factor analysis for each of the contexts , using principal components analysis with varimax rotation and then compared the brand and e-store EFA results to identify a common factor structure applicable to both contexts . As a result of the initial EFA , five items , which cross-loaded on multiple factors or loaded on different factors for the brand and e-store contexts were eliminated . The final EFA Variable Items

Self-relevance of the retail brand I enjoy shopping ***LOADED in this brand 's stores I like the way this brand 's clothes look on me This brand appeals to people like me I like this brand 's clothes I shop at this brand 's stores often Perceived e-store brand fit The impression of this website is similar to the brand 's image The impression of this website is consistent with the brand 's image This website represents the brand 's image very well E-store patronage intention The likelihood that I would make a purchase at this website in the future is very high I would be willing to purchase from this website I would recommend this website to my friend I would spend more time than planned at

this website I would visit this website again I intend to shop at this website

in the future In the future , this website would be one of the first places I

would look when I need to find clothing items Table .

Measurements ***LOADED :

self-relevance , perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention ,

with the remaining items revealed a consistent four-factor structure for both

contexts . The four factors were labeled as enthusiasm , sophistication ,

genuineness and unpleasantness , following the original dimension names from

d'Astous and Levesque . Confirmatory factor analysis was then run with the

finalized -item , -factor model , which revealed a good fit for both brand

personality ***LOADED and e-store personality ***LOADED .

The average

variance extracted and composite reliability estimates were greater than . for

all four personality ***LOADED factors for both brands and e-stores , which

indicated the convergent validity of the factors . The AVE estimates were

greater than all of the squared factor correlations for both the brand and

e-store contexts , which suggests the discriminant validity among the

personality ***LOADED factors . All four factors showed acceptable reliability

for both the brand and e-store data . The six brands ' brand personality

***LOADED and e-store personality ***LOADED factor mean scores revealed variabilities within and across the brands . For example , Talbots was perceived to be the most enthusiastic but the least sophisticated brand among the six brands , whereas Burberry was perceived to be the least enthusiastic but the most sophisticated brand . The brand and e-store personality ***LOADED scores tended to trend together but were not exactly identical , suggesting the ecological validity of the e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence construct . For example , although Burberry was the most sophisticated brand , its e-store was perceived to be less sophisticated than Michael Kors ' . To operationalize e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence based on the e-store personality ***LOADED and brand personality ***LOADED scores , the absolute difference between the respondent 's average brand personality ***LOADED factor score and e-store personality ***LOADED factor score was computed in each of Component and itema,b Brand personality ***LOADED E-store personality ***LOADED Loading AVE CR Cronbach 's α Loading AVE CR Cronbach 's α Enthusiasm Enthusiastic . . Dynamic . . Lively . . Sophistication High class . . Elegant . . Genuineness Sincere . . Solid . . Honest . . Reliable . . Hardy . . Trustful . . Welcoming . .

Unpleasantness Irritating . . Superficial . . Annoying . .

Note : a

All item wordings began with " this brand is " and " this website is " for the

brand personality ***LOADED and estore personality ***LOADED , respectively ,

followed by the adjectives listed here ; b The five items eliminated from the

final measurement ***LOADED as a result of the EFA include " [This brand is ,

This website is] reputable , " " stylish , " " chic , " " loud , " and " thriving " Table . CFA results : brand personality ***LOADED and

e-store

personality ***LOADED E-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence Brand

Brand personality_a E-store personality_a E-store brand personality ***LOADED

incongruence_a Perceived e-store brand fit E-store patronage intention

ESGUESGUESGU Abercrombie e Fitch Gap . .

.

. Coldwater creek Talbots

. Michael Kors Burberry

. Total Note : aE Enthusiasm , S

Sophistication , G Genuineness , U Unpleasantness Table .

Factor mean scores ,

the four personality ***LOADED dimensions , following the indirect approach to

measure image incongruence frequently used in the literature .

For example ,

each respondent 's incongruence in the enthusiasm dimension was calculated by

taking the absolute difference between the average of the three enthusiasm

items' scores for the e-store and the average of the three enthusiasm items' scores for the brand. The bigger the absolute difference, the higher the incongruence and thus the lower the congruence. The e-store brand personality

***LOADED incongruence scores ranged – . in genuineness, – . in

sophistication, – . in enthusiasm and – . in unpleasantness.

Hypothesis

testing Structural equation modeling was run using AMOS to test the hypotheses

. Before running the SEM, a CFA was first conducted to examine the measurement

***LOADED model of the three latent variables: e-store brand personality

***LOADED incongruence, perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage

intention. The initial CFA resulted in an acceptable model fit, but produced

a low factor loading of the "unpleasantness

incongruence" indicator for the

e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence factor.

Given that this

indicator reflects the only negatively-worded personality

***LOADED dimension

, its lack of convergent validity was not surprising. Thus, another CFA was

run after eliminating the unpleasant incongruence indicator, which resulted in

a good fit. To assess the convergent validity of the measurement

***LOADED

model, the values of factor loadings, AVE and CR have been reviewed. The AVE

of one factor , e-store brand personality ***LOADED
incongruence , was below
the recommended threshold of . . However , literature guides that
a scale can
be considered as adequate if other measures support convergent
validity because
AVE is more conservative compared to other measures , and thus
CR and factor
loadings were further examined . CR values were greater than .
for all factors
including e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence ,
indicating their
convergent validity . All factor loadings were statistically
significant , and
their estimated values were within the acceptable range for all
indicators
except for the sophistication incongruence indicator , which was
still above
the threshold factor loading of . . Literature suggests that
indicators with
factor loadings between . and . can remain in the model if they
contribute to
content validity . All AVEs were larger than all of the squared
factor
correlations , which established the discriminant validity among
the factors .
Finally , the internal consistency of all of the factors was
established
through the high CR values and Cronbach 's α s greater than . .
Latent variable
AVE and squared factor correlation ABC CR Cronbach 's α E-
store brand
incongruence . . . E-store/brand fit E-store patronage
Note :

a The italic numbers in diagonal cells are AVEs , while those in the

off-diagonal cells are squared factor correlations Table .

Measurement

***LOADED model CFA results : AVEs , squared factor correlations and Cronbach

's α s of the latent variables E-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence

The SEM model for testing hypotheses through was specified as presented in

Figure and run with maximum likelihood estimation method and , bootstrapping

samples . The fit of this SEM model was acceptable . Both H and H were

supported through the respective regression coefficients , which indicated that

e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence negatively influenced

perceived e-store brand fit , which in turn positively influenced e-store

patronage intention . This result indicates that e-store brand incongruence has

a negative impact on e-store brand fit , while perceived e-store fit positively

influences e-store patronage intention . The direct path from e-store brand

personality ***LOADED incongruence to e-store patronage intention was

non-significant in this model ; although an additional SEM model which

separately examined it without the perceived e-store brand fit mediator showed

a significant relationship between the incongruence and intention variables .

The indirect effect of e-store brand incongruence on e-store patronage intention via perceived e-store brand fit was significant . Combined , these results support H by showing evidence for the full mediation of perceived e-store brand fit for the relationship between e-store brand personality

***LOADED incongruence and e-store patronage intention
 . . Fit Fit

Fit - . Perceived E-Store-Brand Fit PI PI PI PI PI PI PI E-Store

Patronage Intention . . . Enthusiasm Incongruence Genuineness Incongruence

Sophistication Incongruence E-Store-Brand Personality

***LOADED Incongruence

Note : $p < .$, $p < .$ Figure . SEM model and results . All error terms are

omitted , and no error terms are correlated , To test H , multiple-group SEM

was conducted with the high and low self-relevance groups created by a median

split of perceived self-relevance factor scores . Prior to the SEM , an EFA and

Cronbach 's α verified the unidimensionality and internal consistency of the

self-relevance measure , respectively . The multiple-group SEM results revealed

that the relationship between perceived e-store brand fit and e-store patronage

intention was stronger among the high self-relevance group than among the low

self-relevance group . This result indicates that self-relevance significantly

moderates the relationship between e-store brand fit and e-store patronage intention in that this relationship is more salient for consumers with high self-relevance than consumers with low self-relevance . This group difference was statistically supported through a chi-square difference test between this model and another model with this regression coefficient restricted to be equal between the high and low self-relevance groups . Thus , H was supported .

Further , an additional moderation test was run using multiple regression analysis employing the composite score of the three perceived e-store brand fit items , the composite score of the five self-relevance items and the interaction term created by multiplying these two composite scores as three predictors of e-store patronage intention . Results from this analysis again confirmed the significant moderating effect of self-relevance by showing a significant positive effect of the self-relevance fit interaction term , providing additional support for H . Discussion ***LOADED In this study , the symbolic image congruence between the multichannel retail brand and its estore was operationalized in terms of the personality ***LOADED discrepancy in three dimensions : enthusiasm , sophistication and genuineness . This personality-based symbolic image incongruence significantly predicts the

consumer 's perceived e-store brand fit , or global judgment of the congruence of the e-store image to the retail brand image . This result suggests personality ***LOADED , specifically the three personality ***LOADED factors , as a potential strategic dimension to control consumers ' overall e-store brand fit perception . The findings ***LOADED of this study further indicate that consumers ' perceived e-store brand fit significantly influences their patronage intention toward the multichannel retailer 's e-store and that this fit perception is a more direct and stronger influencer of the consumer 's e-store patronage intention than the e-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence . This finding ***LOADED advocates the importance of brand fit of an e-store in fostering consumers ' positive relationship with the e-store and suggests a critical need to delve into various additional potential factors impacting perceived e-store brand fit besides e-store brand personality ***LOADED incongruence examined in this study . Lastly , the findings ***LOADED of this study show that the influence of e-store brand fit is far greater among consumers who perceive a high self-relevance of the retail brand . That is , an apparel brand 's e-store 's fit with the brand 's image matters

more to consumers who have liked and frequently used the brand and thus have felt the brand is highly relevant to them , as compared to consumers who are new to the brand or who have not liked the brand and thus feel less self-relevance to the brand . Retailers ' – rule stresses the importance of satisfying a small number of loyal customers who bring the most profit to the retailer , who are expected to feel the most self-relevance of the retailer .

The findings ***LOADED of this study clearly indicate the strategic importance of maintaining an e-store well-fitting the brand image from the customer relationship management ***LOADED perspective . Theoretical implications This study makes several significant contributions to the literature . First , this study expands brand image congruence research to the cross-channel congruence phenomenon in the E-store brand personality ***LOADED congruence multichannel retailing context . Although research on cross-channel congruence exists , surprisingly little attention has been paid to the issue of cross-channel symbolic image congruence , such as designing e-store interfaces to generate e-store personality ***LOADED impressions reflecting brand personality ***LOADED , as compared to the cross-channel functional integration effect .

Further , previous studies identifying strong linkages between brand image congruence and consumer behaviors have been conducted mainly in a single business channel , such as the contexts of brand extension , product branding and service marketing ***LOADED . This study addresses this literature gap by providing empirical evidence to suggest the critical significance of personality-based cross-channel symbolic image integration of multichannel apparel retailers . Second , this study examined multichannel retailers ' cross-channel image congruence issues both at the global image congruence level and at a specific symbolic personality ***LOADED level . Although perceived e-store brand fit is a more direct and holistic construct of congruence between a multichannel retailer 's brand image and its e-store image perceived by consumers , examining it alone would not provide specific actionable insights on the source of this fit perception . Our findings ***LOADED uncover the intimate connection ***LOADED of personality ***LOADED congruence to an overall e-store brand fit perception , suggesting personality ***LOADED as a critical factor in the cross-channel image congruence management ***LOADED . This study also extends the brand personality ***LOADED and store personality ***LOADED literature , which advocates the significant role of personality

***LOADED congruence in attracting positive consumer response
, by offering

empirical evidence specifically for three positive personality

***LOADED

dimensions that play a role in consumers ' perception of e-store
brand fit and

e-store patronage intention . Finally , this study contributes to the
cognitive

psychology literature as well as the image congruence literature
by offering

empirical evidence for the role of personal relevance in the
consumer 's image

information processing and persuasion . The significant
interaction between

self-relevance and e-store brand fit found in this study
demonstrates that

consumers ' judgment of the e-store brand fit has a greater impact
when

consumers feel higher selfrelevance to the brand , which
motivates them to

process more critically the congruence of the e-store to the retail
brand image

to form their behavioral intention toward the e-store . This finding

***LOADED

extends the applicability of the elaboration likelihood model ,
which predicts

the role of relevance in facilitating elaborate information
processing , to the

context of consumers ' processing of image information . Existing
research in

image congruence has mainly focused on the direct effect of
congruence between

the consumer 's self-image and the image of the brand or the
store , such as

brand-self congruence , store-self congruence and the e-store-self congruence ,
on consumer responses to the brand or the store . This study
takes a unique
look at the relationship among the triad of the consumer , the
brand and its
e-store by integrating the cognitive psychology perspective into
the image
congruence perspective and provides a new insight on how the
consumer 's
self-relevance to the brand interacts with the under-investigated
image
congruence between the brand and its e-store to drive the
consumer 's patronage
toward the brand 's e-store . Managerial ***LOADED implications
The current
study contributes practical guidelines with regard to multichannel
retail
brands ' e-store design . First , this study reveals that enhancing
cross-channel image similarity , consistency , or connectedness is
a key factor
for successful multichannel apparel retailing , and particularly the
symbolic
image congruence in personality ***LOADED may be key to
multichannel , apparel
retailers ' cross-channel brand management ***LOADED .
Therefore ,
multichannel apparel retail brand managers ***LOADED should
carefully identify
their brand personality ***LOADED and integrate it into their
estore interface
design and e-store visual merchandising to convey an estore
personality
***LOADED that is consistent with the retail brand 's personality
***LOADED .

Second , this study shows that a mismatch between a consumer 's existing perceptions of the retailer 's brand personality ***LOADED negatively impacts perceived image fit between the brand and its e-store and eventually may harm patronage intention for the retailer 's e-store , especially among the retailer 's target consumer group , who may feel the mismatch more acutely than consumers who do not see the retailer has much to offer them . New customers , who are not well aware of the brand 's image and thus have not formed a sense of self-relevance to the brand , may not be bothered by an image misfit of the e-store to the brand . However , the misfit between the brand image and the e-store image may have a detrimental impact on loyal customers who feel high relevance of the brand to themselves , which may lead to harming the customers ' relationships with the brand and discouraging them from using the brand 's estore . Given that apparel brands always strive to enhance their relevance to their target customers and maintain their relevance to their loyal customers , the findings ***LOADED of this study lend a critical implication for the importance of designing and executing a brand 's e-store with their target and/or loyal customers ' perceived image of the brand in mind . Brands need to

manage ***LOADED target consumers by offering consistent and meaningful

***LOADED brand associations to induce a high image fit .

Further , brands

need to increase their level of relevance to the target customer by examining

their needs and wants continuously to satisfy their expectations and achieve a

stronger brand loyalty . In conclusion , a lack of image congruence caused by

personality ***LOADED mismatches between the retail channels can potentially

result in a detrimental feedback effect on the retail brand image by diluting

the true identity of the retailer in the consumer 's minds .

Therefore , the

seamless cross-channel integration using intangible symbolic image congruence ,

such as personality ***LOADED congruence , must be carefully executed for

multichannel retail branding . Retailers should view multichannel retailing

strategies from an integrated brand management ***LOADED perspective so that

their customers can have a unified shopping ***LOADED experience , consistent

and effective , across multiple channels both symbolically and functionally .

The symbolic integration through shared personality ***LOADED and other

self-expressive benefits as well as the functional integration focusing on

consistency in tangible attributes between channels should be assured for

successful multichannel branding . Limitations and recommendations Findings

***LOADED from this study should be understood with caution in light of the

following limitations . First , this study focuses on the cross-channel image

congruence from the symbolic image perspective . In doing so , the potential

congruence dimensions from the functional image perspective were not included

in this study . Further , among many potential symbolic image dimensions , this

study focuses only on the personality-based image by examining the e-store

brand personality ***LOADED congruence in the three personality ***LOADED

dimensions . In addition , the e-store brand personality ***LOADED

incongruence factor had a low AVE , which may raise a convergent validity

concern although CR and factor loadings were acceptable .

Therefore , future

research is recommended to pursue E-store brand personality ***LOADED

congruence more comprehensive insights on the cross-channel image congruence

effects in various symbolic and functional image dimensions and use more valid

assessment methods for symbolic image congruence . Second , although

self-relevance has been incorporated in this study as a moderator , a

perception of self-relevance of a retail brand may stem from many specific

factors of the retailer or the consumer ; therefore , future research

addressing how different factors of self-relevance may moderate the relationship between e-store brand fit and e-store patronage is recommended to generate clearer insights to help businesses to connect with consumers .

Further , results of this study might have been impacted by additional potential confounding variables , such as consumers ' level of different brand associations , including prior brand knowledge ***LOADED , experience , or familiarity with the brand/e-store and their personality ***LOADED or shopping ***LOADED tendencies , which were unaccounted for in this study . Future research with the inclusion of these potential confounding variables as moderators may provide valuable insights on how consumers ' sensitivity to the crosschannel image congruence effect may vary depending on levels of the moderators . Last , because the sample consisted of only female consumers from certain age groups , the findings ***LOADED may not be generalized to other populations . Further , although care was taken to use brands representing a variety of personality ***LOADED characteristics in this study , the generalizability beyond the six apparel retailers used in this study may be limited . Future research is recommended to extend this study to other

populations and to e-store contexts of other brands or other product categories , so that the external validity of the findings ***LOADED can be enhanced .

Further , this study included only the e-store channel to examine the brand image congruence effect . Additional research delving into image congruence across more diverse retail channels , such as mobile commerce , voice-commerce and social media , may offer more comprehensive insights into the cross-channel image congruence issue for strategic omnichannel branding .